



THE MODERN



DAVID SHAW
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TARTLET

Smoked Salmon, Sugar Snap Peas, Horseradish Cream, and Citrus Zest

LOBSTER

Chilled Lobster, Shiso Leaves, Green Radish Slices, Cara Cara and Orange Emulsion

SEA BASS

Sea Bass with Crosnes and Shishito Pepper, Basil, Turnip
Sugar Snap Pea, and a Sudachi Vegetable Broth

EGGS ON EGGS ON EGGS

Kaluga Caviar, Poached Egg Yolk, Egg Sauce, Fried Brioche, Fresh Dill and Dill Oil

SCALLOP

Seared Diver Scallop, Clam Beurre Noisette
White Asparagus from Provence, and Beluga Lentils

LAMB

Australian Spring Lamb Saddle, Dates, Cabbage, Morel Mushrooms
Romanesco Purée, and a Citrus Rosemary Sauce

CARROT

Carrot Cinnamon Sponge Cake, Pineapple Ice Cream, and Cream Cheese Sabayon
Carrot Caramel Sauce and Carrot Orange Purée

YUZU

Yuzu Gelato, Crispy Meringue, Citrus Chiffon



My first visit to The Modern took place exactly eight years ago. Now, as the restaurant marks its twentieth anniversary, it feels as though I have lived through nearly half of its history, and a return seems almost self-explanatory. The extremely high ceilings, the contemporary yet artistic interior design, the ample sunlight, the MoMA garden, the elegant plating, and the classically composed flavors, all combine to make The Modern my singular favorite lunch spot, and one of my favorite places to dine in Manhattan.

The booking process, however, already reveals a sense of ennui, as the email communication proves inefficient. The initial message appears warm, introducing in detail the arrival of spring at The Modern with an emphasis of the presence of two precious seasonal ingredients. Soon enough, I realize the highly formulaic tone of the greeting, and that these ingredients will most likely not even appear on the menu. I am asked whether there is any special occasion, to which I reply that this visit carries personal significance, as I am marking the eighth anniversary of my first meal at The Modern. The message, however, does not go directly to the restaurant, but to this so-called experience specialist, whose subsequent communication with the restaurant proves inaccurate — when we are seated, the staff assume we are celebrating a romantic anniversary.

That being said, a quiet joy still takes over as I re-enter the space and return to the oval table I have always preferred, a rare vantage point from which I can observe every movement in the dining room.



As soon as we settle on the prix-fixe menu selections, a complimentary tartlet amuse-bouche has made its return — it appeared on my first visit, then disappeared — which now seems like a clever way to conceal the fact that the lunch menu has been reduced from four courses to three. Set within a double-layered tartlet shell are smoked salmon rillette and sugar snap peas, married by a horseradish cream and finished with a bright, prominent spray of citrus zest. The combination of smoked salmon and green peas builds a classic flavor profile, one that quickly reminds us of the salmon feuille de brick we had days ago at César. The horseradish adds a touch of spice, though it contributes more warmth and a soothing depth than pungency. The most comforting element, however, is the citrus. With a presence more pronounced than expected, its acidity is bright yet elegant. Its sweetness echoes that of the peas, while its sharpness complements the smoked salmon. A brilliant bite, leading the palate across the threshold into the world of The Modern.



Following the tartlet, the appetizer courses present a chilled lobster and a warm sea bass. The chilled lobster dish is accompanied by shiso leaves, green radish slices, and segments of cara cara orange, finished with an orange emulsion; alongside it stands a warm sea bass dish with crosnes and shishito peppers, joined by basil, poached turnip, and sugar snap peas, all settled in a sudachi-accented vegetable broth.

The chilled lobster immediately strikes us with its dreamy color composition — a vivid, saturated palette of green, yellow, red, and purple, half-veiled beneath translucent turnip slices. Its painterly arrangement makes the restaurant's place within the MoMA feel almost self-explanatory. On the palate, the lobster once again impresses with its bounciness: a lively, resilient texture that earns itself a unique place — one that holds its own against the delicate tenderness of the langoustine we had at Aska. The flavor profile, though refreshing, is all-encompassing. The herbal basil, the brightly sweet cara cara, and the restrained, almost zen-like turnip together create a colorful harmony around the lobster.



Moving from the cold dish to the warm sea bass, the crisp skin immediately captures our attention. The flesh is prepared to a refined tenderness, the flakes falling apart on the tongue like tofu, while the skin remains crisp, carrying a mesmerizing, lightly charred aroma. Beneath lies a shishito and sudachi-centered vegetable broth, which, thanks to the shishito, introduces an unexpected angle to the flavor profile. The sudachi, at the same time, adds a gentle citrus lift, its acidity expressed in a restrained, quietly vibrant manner. Another catchy touch is the somewhat unconventional use of the crosnes. Often called Chinese artichokes, these small, tuberous vegetables offer a slightly firm texture with a mild, nutty, faintly sweet flavor. Their presence, alongside shishito peppers and radishes, signals a clear inspiration from East Asian cuisines. The sea bass itself, tender and mild, functions as a canvas, allowing the shishito and crosnes to elevate the dish with a subtle but distinct excitement.





The menu has shrunk from four courses to three, eliminating the pièce de résistance — Eggs on Eggs on Eggs. While we had two caviar courses the night before at Aska, this presentation leans more traditional. With an additional seventy-five dollars, we add a serving to share. The dish proves as satisfying as it lingers in memory. Holding the airy, crisp brioche stick like a spoon, we scoop up a portion of the egg sauce and caviar and bring it to the palate. The flavor is as expected, but it is the precision, the finesse, the balance that once again give rise to goosebumps. Though the three layers of egg may sound overwhelming, the texture of the brioche acts as the primary counterbalance to the creaminess. The caviar is actually not a prominent component, given its limited quantity, yet its oceanic umami stirs quietly in the background with power beyond imagination. Together with the dill oil, it forms an underlying force that further tempers the richness of the mayonnaise and egg yolk.



Moving on to the mains, we are served a scallop and a lamb dish. As we decide to share everything, the scallop naturally becomes the first we savor. Its sauce, a clam beurre noisette, is what we choose to taste first. A faint caramelized aroma emerges as the butter is taken to a noisette stage, further augmented by a touch of clam that introduces a gentle oceanic depth. We then raise the knife and cut through the scallop. It is immediately apparent that it has been perfectly executed: browned and crisp on the outside, while the interior remains translucent. The outer layer, while beautifully golden and crusted, reads slightly harsh on the tongue. A more refined texture would be expected at this level of finesse. What lies beneath the scallop is where the dish becomes truly compelling. The Beluga lentils, with their delicate, lightly firm texture, bring a vivid textural contrast. Their earthy, meaty, slightly nutty profile stands in counterpoint to the elegant sweetness and tender delicacy of the white asparagus sourced from Provence. Together, they expand the stage, allowing the scallop to express itself to its fullest.



A slight regret arises as we move on to the lamb dish: an overly long wait cools the meat to a temperature at which its gaminess becomes overwhelmingly pronounced. Nevertheless, it is precisely this otherwise undesirable note that proves the brilliance of the composition. As we take another cut of the lamb and pair it with everything else — an equal-sized sheet of cabbage, a touch of the dates beneath it, some morel mushrooms, a bit of romanesco purée, all dipped into the citrus-rosemary sauce — the gamey intensity is immediately tamed. Even at a less-than-ideal temperature, the combination brings genuine satisfaction to the palate. It reveals a careful, deliberate design. Where the milder sea bass allowed its accompanying elements to read prominently, here, with a protein as assertive as lamb, the supporting components are notably restrained. The dates might seem the most unexpected element, and just as they surprised us in the raw tuna at Bridges, they introduce a caramelized sweetness to the lamb, this time with a slightly gummy texture, mind-blowing yet harmonious.



As we linger on the mellow, almost mesmerizing sweetness of the dates in the lamb dish, that sweetness carries forward into the dessert courses. Curated by executive pastry chef Charlotte Brecher, one features a citrus chiffon cake topped with yuzu gelato and meringue, while the other presents an unconventional carrot cake. As both include time-sensitive ice cream, we begin to enjoy them simultaneously.

The yuzu dessert, while simple in design and straightforward in concept, is refreshing and finely executed. At the base rests a layer of chiffon cake, and on top of this airy foundation lies a thin cracker. On the surface, dots of meringue and a quenelle of yuzu gelato further crown the composition. The overall idea suggests a dialogue between Japanese inspiration and American design. There is nothing overtly complex, yet finesse is evident in every detail, and a precise balance is achieved. The citrus-driven profile lends the dessert a lightness that is immediately approachable through its light texture. With one spoonful, the weight of the gelato gently breaks through the cracker and chiffon, delivering everything in a single bite: velvety gelato, crisp cracker, airy meringue, and a fluffy, almost weightless chiffon base.



The carrot dessert, according to Charlotte, aims to deliver a composition that plays with familiarity. The dish incorporates the elements of a classic carrot cake, but reinterprets them in ways diners may not expect. At the center of the plate rests a soil base of carrot cake sponge, flavored with cinnamon, ginger, and pineapple. Beneath this lies a dehydrated cream cheese sabayon, whose texture is remarkably airy and powdery, reminiscent of something treated with liquid nitrogen. A swirl of pineapple ice cream is then placed on top. On the side, two sauces accompany the dish. One is a carrot caramel, cooked down with cinnamon, allspice, clove, carrot juice, and brown butter; the other a carrot-orange purée, composed of carrots, carrot juice, sugar, and mandarin juice. While carrot cake itself is rooted in a traditional European dessert framework, the flavor profile here is notably refined and restrained, reflecting a more modern, East Asian sensibility in dessert-making. The form of the ice cream, though not uncommon, is more often seen in French establishments, lending the dish a clean, elegant appearance. In its deconstructed form, the carrot cake clearly expresses the chef's meticulous design — rather than merely tossing its components, the dish reorders them with intention.



To step back slightly in the timeline, just before the desserts are presented, a celebratory cake is brought to the table ahead of the desserts, intended to honor the occasion. Visually, the cake is striking, with white chocolate fashioned to resemble the soft drip of candle wax. In execution, however, it remains relatively ordinary. It is nothing more than a straightforward lemon cake, with the white chocolate contributing more to appearance than to flavor.



The issue is less the cake itself than the ambiguity surrounding its purpose. While the gesture is undeniably warm, the nature of the celebration appears uncertain. One server assumes a romantic anniversary, another suggests it marks my eighth visit to the restaurant, neither quite accurate. The sense of ennui noted earlier quietly persists. When desserts are eventually presented, the experience is further unsettled by a lapse in service. A senior member of the staff conducts himself with a noticeable lack of attentiveness: used cutlery is returned to the table, requests for fresh utensils are met with visible reluctance, and the interaction surrounding the bill feels procedural rather than hospitable. When I mention the anticipated kitchen tour, I am asked to settle the bill first—a policy that, while understandable, is rarely encountered. The subsequent tour itself feels perfunctory, and even a request for a group photograph is received with hesitation.

And yet, despite these inconsistencies in service, the meal itself remains thoughtfully composed, at times even remarkable. The Modern continues to demonstrate a clarity of culinary vision, one that, at its best, balances precision, restraint, and quiet creativity. It is precisely this strength that makes the surrounding imperfections more noticeable, and is what ultimately invites a return.

